Mean-Field Theory of Two-Layer Neural Networks

Song Mei, Theodor Misiakiewicz, Andrea Montanari

COLT 2019

Paper 61 | Ref 89 | Tags: S, D, A / F, B | Skim

The paper in one minute

Question: Can a very wide two-layer network be analyzed by tracking a *distribution* of neurons instead of every weight, without width requirements scaling with input dimension?
Model/Method: Represent the N neurons by an empirical probability measure; compare one-pass SGD with a transport PDE (and a diffusion PDE for injected noise).
Finding: The authors derive stronger finite-width mean-field approximation bounds, dimension-free in important regimes; extend to some unbounded activations and noisy SGD; recover kernel regression as a special scaling limit.
Why we care: Wide-network training has a *feature-learning, distributional* description; the frozen-kernel regime is only one limiting case.

1. Replace a list of neurons by a population

A two-layer network is a sum of feature-producing neurons. In the mean-field normalization,

$$\widehat{f}_N(x) = \frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N} \sigma_*(x;\theta_i), \qquad \widehat{\rho}_N = \frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N} \delta_{\theta_i}.$$

The Dirac mass δ_{θ_i} is a point mass at neuron i's parameters. Thus the same predictor can be written as an integral:

$$\widehat{f}_N(x) = \int \sigma_*(x;\theta)\, \widehat{\rho}_N(d\theta).$$

Interpretation. Moving from N weights to a probability measure ρ is like studying the density of particles rather than following every particle. The distribution *moves*: this is different from freezing initial features in an NTK approximation.

Worked example: empirical measure in one dimension

Let each neuron output $\sigma_*(x;w) = wx$ and take two weights $w_1 = 1$, $w_2 = 3$. Their empirical distribution is $\widehat{\rho} = \frac{1}{2}\delta_1 + \frac{1}{2}\delta_3$. For input $x = 2$,

$$\widehat{f}_2(2) = \tfrac{1}{2}(1\cdot 2 + 3\cdot 2) = 4 = \int 2w\, \widehat{\rho}(dw).$$

If a gradient update moves both neurons, the locations of the point masses change, so ρ_t evolves. A continuum description replaces these discrete masses with a smoothly evolving distribution when the network is wide enough.

From gradient flow to a distributional PDE

The potential $\Psi(\theta;\rho)$ describes how the population risk changes when probability mass moves at θ. Its characteristic velocity is proportional to $-\nabla_\theta \Psi$. Conservation of mass yields a transport equation of the form

$$\partial_t \rho_t = 2\xi(t)\, \nabla_\theta \cdot \big(\rho_t \nabla_\theta \Psi(\theta;\rho_t)\big).$$

This is a *Wasserstein gradient-flow* viewpoint, not ordinary gradient flow in a fixed vector of parameters.

2. What is genuinely improved by this paper?

The finite-width comparison

Section 3 compares the actual population risk of finite-width, discrete SGD, $R_N(\theta^k)$, with the risk $R(\rho_{k\varepsilon})$ predicted by the mean-field PDE. Theorem 3 provides high-probability approximation bounds for noiseless SGD. In the fixed-second-layer-coefficient regime, the bound has the schematic shape

$$\sup_{k\le T/\varepsilon} |R_N(\theta^k) - R(\rho_{k\varepsilon})| \lesssim C_T \left(\frac{\sqrt{\log N} + z}{\sqrt{N}} + \sqrt{\varepsilon}\,(\sqrt{D} + \sqrt{\log N} + z) \right).$$

This display is a *schematic simplification* of Eq. (9), not a substitute for its precise constants, conditions, and logarithms. Crucially, the $N^{-1/2}$ term does not have a dimension multiplier in important regimes. A small enough step size remains necessary and can itself depend on D.

Noisy SGD introduces diffusion

When the SGD update includes deliberately injected Gaussian noise, the limiting PDE contains a Laplacian term:

$$\partial_t \rho_t = 2\xi(t)\nabla \cdot (\rho_t \nabla \Psi_\lambda) + \frac{2\xi(t)\tau}{D}\Delta_\theta \rho_t.$$

The transport term moves the population according to risk; the Laplacian spreads it. Theorem 4 extends the approximation, but *its general-coefficient noisy case is not dimension-free* (Remark 5).

When does mean-field reduce to a kernel method?

In Section 4, increasing a model-output scaling parameter makes the neuron distribution move only weakly over a rescaled time interval. Then the evolving kernel operator H_{ρ_t} is approximately its initial value H_{ρ_0}, and the prediction residual obeys

$$\partial_t u_t \simeq -H_{\rho_0} u_t.$$

This is linear kernel dynamics, and an associated limit recovers kernel regression. It is a *special limit* of mean-field dynamics, not the entire mean-field theory.

> **Read correctly:** "Dimension-free" refers to particular width-dependent approximation terms under bounded regularity constants. It is not a claim that all sample, step-size and computational requirements are independent of dimension.

3. Contributions, assumptions, and limits

Contributions. (i) Stronger approximation guarantees for the finite-neuron SGD dynamics, including width bounds that can avoid explicit dimension dependence; (ii) extensions beyond bounded activations and to noisy stochastic gradients; (iii) identification of kernel regression as a limiting version of the same distributional model. **Assumptions.** One-pass i.i.d. sampling, suitable small steps, independent neuron initialization, bounded or sub-Gaussian data-related quantities, regularity and Lipschitz properties of the potentials V, U, with extra initialization/smoothness conditions for noisy SGD (Assumptions A1–A6). Some claims fix output-layer coefficients; others update them. **Limitations.** Results depend on distributional regularity and time horizons; approximation errors may grow with time. The different noisy/general-coefficient cases do not share the same dimension-free rate. The paper is not a universal convergence-to-global-minimum result for deep networks.

Survey connections

Lu et al. (Ref 90) transports distributional reasoning from two-layer networks into a special continuous-depth ResNet. **Li–Ma–Zhang (Ref 91)** shows that networks that actually move their features can learn targets inaccessible to polynomial-size fixed kernels. **Arora et al. (Ref 87)** studies a frozen-kernel spectrum; this paper clarifies where that description arises.

Quick reference

Concept	Meaning
$\widehat{\rho}_N = N^{-1} \sum_i \delta_{\theta_i}$	Distribution of the finite set of neuron parameters.
ρ_t	Mean-field population distribution evolving in training time.
Transport PDE	Conservation of probability mass under neuron drift.
Diffusion term $\Delta\rho$	Spread from injected noise.
H_{ρ_0}	Fixed initial kernel in the small-movement limit.

Papers Master note

Mei–Misiakiewicz–Montanari (2019) sharpen mean-field approximations of two-layer SGD by tracking distributions of neurons. Width-dependent approximation terms can avoid explicit dimension dependence under regularity conditions; they also treat noisy SGD and show that fixed-kernel regression is a special scaling limit.

Source: COLT 2019 original, Sections 3–4, Theorems 3–4, Remark 5. Toy example and schematic bound are explanatory.